

Brihadeeshwara Temple, Thanjavur



Gangaikonda Cholapuram Temple

Cholapuram. The magnificent Thanjavur Big Temple dedicated to Siva, completed around AD (CE) 1009, is a fitting memorial to the material achievements of the time of Rajaraja.

Thanjavur Big Temple

At the time the Big Temple of Thanjavur was constructed, it was a huge temple complex. The 216 feet *vimana* (structure over the *garbhagriha*) is notable as it is one among the tallest man-made *shikaras* of the world. Due to its massive height, the *shikara* is called the Dakshina Meru. The huge bull statue (Nandi) measures about 16 feet long and 13 feet height and is carved out of a single rock

Gangaikonda Cholapuram

Gangaikonda Cholapuram served as the Chola capital for about 250 years, until the decline of the Cholas and the rise of the Pandyas. The Brihadeeshwara temple of Gangaikonda Cholapuram, built by Rajendra Chola, is undoubtedly as worthy a successor to the Brihadeeshwara temple of Thanjavur. The height of the temple is 55 metres. The sanctum has two storeys as in the big temple at Thanjavur. The outer wall has many projections with niches and recesses on three sides. In the niches there are the images of Siva, Vishnu and other gods. This temple complex has the shrines of Chandeeswarar, Ganesa and Mahishasura Mardhini.

Dharasuram

Dharasuram, near Kumbakonam, is a Later Chola period temple, rich in architectural splendour, dedicated to Iravatheswara (Siva as god of lord Indira's elephant). Rajaraja II constructed this temple. This temple is another landmark of the Chola architecture. The *Mahamandapam* is an elaborate structure. The entire structure looks like a *ratha* because it has four wheels at the *Mahamandapam*. The sanctum and pillars have many sculptures, which are miniatures of various mythological figures. A compound wall runs round the temple with a *gopuram*.



Iravatheswara Temple